

Chapter 140-1

Qin Lishuang's name suddenly appeared before her eyes.

Liang Shi's words came to an abrupt halt.

Chen Mian noticed her pause and took out a can of cold beer from the refrigerator, handing it over. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Liang Shi turned the ticket over to look at it. It really was a very artistic design—even she, an outsider, thought it looked high-end.

She opened the pull-tab can, and as the cold beer entered her mouth, the coolness spread throughout her body.

It calmed her emotions down.

Liang Shi's fingertips rubbed against the ticket surface as she carefully asked: "Do you know... Qin Lishuang?"

"Mm." Chen Mian sat casually on the sofa. Her hair was clipped up with a white hair clip, with a few strands hanging by the sides of her face. Part of her arm was exposed, and her glasses had been tossed aside.

She sat with her legs crossed, looking particularly languid. Even her voice was lazy. "We're not that familiar."

"Do you know her?" Chen Mian asked.

After thinking about it, Liang Shi nodded: "I suppose."

The memories she possessed were nothing more than Qin Lishuang tying the original owner to a cold metal bed, admiring the original owner's world-weary face with great interest, using that as inspiration for her paintings.

She liked all things dark.

It was very despicable behavior.

The original owner was treated like a pet, not a person.

For the original owner, who was already an adult at the time, it was extremely humiliating.

But under Qiu Zimin's control, she still did it.

Even though Liang Xinzhou later came to find her and took her away from Qin Lishuang, what was meant to happen had already happened.

The cold, stinging sensation on her body, humiliation and despair intertwined.

Liang Shi could no longer feel her despair from that time, but the memories from before were all still there.

Qin Lishuang was also an important part of Liang Shi's evidence collection.

Liang Shi accepted Chen Mian's tickets. "I'll go too."

"As you wish." Chen Mian said.

Chen Mian quickly finished a can of cold beer and easily tossed the crushed can into the trash.

Liang Shi glanced sideways at her.

That plain face carried a hint of indifference.

The room was quiet for a long time. Liang Shi also finished her can of cold beer. Just as she was about to leave, Chen Mian stood up: "Let's go. Let's go out to eat."

Liang Shi: "?"

Chen Mian grabbed her keys from the doorway and casually threw on a jacket that looked somewhat worn.

She frowned as she stood in the entryway, having some difficulty when she squatted down.

It was only then that Liang Shi noticed one of her legs wasn't quite right.

"Your leg..." Liang Shi was surprised.

Chen Mian finished putting on her shoes and stood up, saying indifferently: "I fell before. Almost broke it."

Chapter 140-2

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Chen Mian brought Liang Shi to a noodle shop.

The noodle shop was located near that middle school, in the deepest part of an alley. Business was slow.

However, it was very warm inside the shop. Shortly after entering, both Liang Shi and Chen Mian took off their coats.

"You brought a friend?" The owner greeted Chen Mian with a smile. "What are you having today?"

Chen Mian didn't ask for Liang Shi's opinion and ordered on her own: "Two bowls of saozhi noodles,¹ and a plate of pickled vegetables."

Liang Shi sat down with her.

Chen Mian pulled two napkins from the side, folded them neatly, and quietly wiped the oil stains on the wooden table.

She didn't talk to Liang Shi anymore.

Chen Mian had no awareness of entertaining a friend.

She was simply treating her to a meal.

The saozhi noodles were indeed very fragrant—better than any noodles Liang Shi had ever eaten before. With a spoonful of chili oil drizzled on top, it was very appetizing.

Liang Shi didn't hold back either.

After they finished eating, Chen Mian paid the bill.

She put on her worn coat again, looking unkempt.

The owner looked at the two of them and teased Chen Mian just as they were about to leave: "Where did you find such a good-looking friend?"

"Just found her randomly." Chen Mian said.

This time she didn't deny what the owner said.

When paying, the owner said: "This is your first time bringing a friend here—twenty percent off."

Chen Mian's hand paused while paying. She lowered her eyelashes and said: "This isn't the first time."

"Many years ago, I also brought someone here." Chen Mian said.

The owner was stunned, and only after a long while did she realize: "Oh, you mean that young girl. That was such a long time ago."

Chen Mian made a sound of acknowledgment, zipped her coat all the way up, and lazily waved at the owner. "Leaving now."

After coming out, the cold wind kept drilling into their clothes.

Liang Shi put her hands in her pockets and watched Chen Mian's back—it looked somewhat desolate.

She jogged a few steps to walk side by side with Chen Mian.

On both sides of the road, only some bare branches and shrubs remained.

The wind had blown this city into bleakness, without a trace of vitality.

After a moment, Liang Shi finally asked: "Have you ever thought about dating?"

Chen Mian was startled: "Who?"

"You." Liang Shi said: "After all, Qi Jiao... is gone."

"Never thought about it." Chen Mian didn't mind talking about Qi Jiao's death. She had a very good mindset when facing death, but her emotions were extremely pessimistic. "Who knows when I might die too. There's no point."

"Huh?" This answer startled Liang Shi. "I thought you just couldn't let go of Qi Jiao."

Chen Mian: "....."

"That too." Chen Mian didn't hide it. "But more than that, I just haven't met anyone I like."

"Alright then."

The topic ended there.

Chen Mian took Liang Shi for a walk around the area—just some after-meal exercise to help digestion.

After all, in Chen Mian's eyes, Liang Shi had also graduated from this school, so there was no need to show her around.

When they were about to part, Liang Shi hesitated but still said: "Someone wanted me to tell you—remember to listen to 'Solitary Bird Syndrome' before bed. Also, someone will love you."

She still helped convey Qi Jiao's words.

Chen Mian was stunned when she heard this. "Gu Xingyue?"

Liang Shi didn't say anything.

Chen Mian lowered her eyelashes. "That song was released a long time ago. Qi Jiao must have written it in her diary."

Liang Shi still didn't answer.

In exchange, Chen Mian warned Liang Shi coldly: "You should also stay away from Qin Lishuang."

Liang Shi: "Oh."

A flash of disdain passed through Chen Mian's eyes as she scoffed lightly: "That one's no good."

When cursing Qin Lishuang, Chen Mian's erhua accent² was particularly obvious.

The disgust and contempt in her tone were also very obvious.

"Got it." Liang Shi thought to herself: I've experienced even more than you have.

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1. Saozi noodles (臊子面) are a traditional noodle dish from Shaanxi province in China, featuring hand-pulled noodles topped with a savory meat sauce made from diced pork, along with various vegetables. It's known for its rich, flavorful broth. ↵
 2. Erhua accent (兒化音) refers to the addition of an "r" sound to the end of syllables, which is characteristic of northern Chinese dialects, particularly Beijing dialect. It often conveys a casual or colloquial tone. ↵

Chapter 140-3

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On Wednesday, after Liang Shi dropped Xu Qingzhu off at work, she drove to the entrance of the media school to pick up Liang Wanwan.

When Liang Wanwan learned she was going to Chen Mian's art exhibition, she was very excited at first. Later, for some unknown reason, her mood became unusually low. After much deliberation, she still decided to go to the exhibition with Liang Shi.

This was Liang Wanwan's last year at school—she was about to graduate soon. The dual pressure of her thesis and job hunting left her with no leisure time.

She didn't even know that Liang Shi had been in a coma for so long before.

She spent most of her time in the classroom, studio, and dormitory. There hadn't been any long holidays recently, so she hadn't even gone back to the Liang family home.

Liang Shi waited at the school entrance for less than two minutes before Liang Wanwan, wearing a white down jacket, appeared at the school gate.

She was carrying a light gray backpack, wearing a white down jacket, a gray knitted hat, and white knee-high boots—a very youthful and beautiful outfit.

Liang Shi honked the horn.

Liang Wanwan jogged over a few steps, opened the car door, and got in. She pressed her hands against her rosy red cheeks and asked gently: "Jie, is it just the two of us?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "Chen Mian only gave me two tickets."

"Alright." Liang Wanwan started fastening her seatbelt.

Along the way, Liang Wanwan, as a semi-"insider," gave Liang Shi some knowledge about art exhibitions.

Especially about this particular exhibition.

As a well-known eccentric genius painter in the industry, Chen Mian's works weren't usually displayed at exhibitions for viewing.

Most of the time, they would appear online or in various competitions.

The thirteen "eccentric genius" painters at this exhibition were all recognized in the industry for their strange painting styles, which could be called absurdist.

But they were different from what was commonly referred to as absurdism in literature.

Absurdism in literature is often satirical, either criticizing current affairs or discussing human nature.

But these painters' strangeness was only in their painting style—either too dark or too bright.

Yet there was nothing wrong with their composition and colors; in fact, they were quite outstanding.

That's why they were praised as "eccentric geniuses."

Among them, the most frequently nominated were Chen Mian and Qin Lishuang.

Chen Mian was famous for her strange landscape paintings.

Qin Lishuang was famous for her strange portraits.

Qin Lishuang was particularly skilled at capturing people's most fearful or darkest moments.

Meanwhile, Chen Mian's paintings had very deep artistic conception.

Originally, there was no point in comparing the two, but one year at an international competition, there were four nominees in total, and Chen Mian, as the youngest, won the award.

That year, everyone had been most optimistic about Qin Lishuang.

Not only that, but two months later, there was another international competition.

The work Qin Lishuang entered was one she had said in an interview was her most satisfying piece. At that time, she was very confident, saying she had a ninety percent chance of winning. But Chen Mian cut in—the only two nominees were Qin Lishuang and Chen Mian.

In the end, Chen Mian won.

Chen Mian, as a newcomer, rose rapidly in the art world.

No one could imitate her painting style.

And reportedly, the work she entered that time was something she had casually painted after drinking too much.

After that, Chen Mian's name frequently appeared in the public eye, becoming as renowned as Qin Lishuang, and later even showing signs of surpassing her.

Qin Lishuang had dominated for so many years—naturally, she couldn't stand someone being so much better than her.

So Chen Mian became a thorn in her side.

Almost every competition Chen Mian entered, Qin Lishuang would also enter.

Later, nothing so dramatic happened again. It was often a case of Chen Mian winning one round and Qin Lishuang winning the next.

Over time, Chen Mian and Qin Lishuang's names became bound together—praising one inevitably meant putting down the other.

Liang Wanwan educated Liang Shi the whole way, finally summarizing: "I don't like Qin Lishuang's painting style either. It's too dark."

"But she has a lot of fans online." Liang Wanwan said: "She's quite good-looking—the mature, cool big sister type."

Liang Shi had just pulled up to the entrance of the art museum.

The exhibition started at ten o'clock, and many people had already arrived by now.

Men and women were gathered in the open space in front of the art museum, chatting casually.

Liang Shi and Liang Wanwan waited quietly until ticket checking began over there.

After having their tickets checked and entering, the venue was unusually quiet.

The organizers had rented two floors for the exhibition, with all kinds of paintings hanging on the walls.

Because it was a fairly famous exhibition in the industry, many people came. Liang Wanwan even ran into her major course professor.

However, they didn't see Chen Mian, Qin Lishuang, or any of the other artists.

Liang Wanwan basically recognized all these painters' faces and said not a single one of them had come.

But she heard from her professor that today's exhibition would also have experience-sharing sessions, though it hadn't been decided who would participate. At least three to five of those painters would show up.

Liang Shi had specifically asked Chen Mian.

Chen Mian said she would come, just a bit later.

The paintings on the walls weren't within Liang Shi's range of appreciation. What she was interested in were Chen Mian's and Qin Lishuang's paintings.

Below each painting was an introduction related to the work.

Other painters had quite lengthy introductions, including the creative intent and meaning behind the painting.

But when it came to Chen Mian's, there were only two characters: Chen Mian.

Everything else was blank.

Qin Lishuang's was also rather sparse—aside from her name, there was only the creation date.

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Chen Mian's paintings were very abstract, but the color combinations were beautiful.

Qin Lishuang's were melancholic in style, mostly featuring portraits.

The knowledge Liang Wanwan shared with Liang Shi also included how to tell whether these paintings were for sale.

If the words "Not For Sale" were written below the introduction section of the painting, it meant it wasn't being sold to the public—generally either already sold or kept by the artist. Those without these three characters were basically for sale, either to be auctioned after the exhibition ended or to be purchased through the organizers by someone who took a liking to them.

Most of the paintings on display were for sale, and all had won awards.

There were three paintings by Qin Lishuang in this venue. Liang Shi felt nothing looking at the first two, but was startled when she saw the third.

That painting was not for sale, and the introduction read: Most Satisfying Work—"Loathing."

The person in the painting had light brown pupils, those eyes full of loathing, with bandages wrapped around her mouth.

Brown curly hair was spread across her skin, and both her arms and legs were bound.

Key areas were partially hidden, very artistic.

The composition was beautiful, and at first glance, it was very impactful.

If the person in the painting wasn't her.

Even she herself had to look hard before recognizing that this was her—or rather, this was the original owner.

What was Qin Lishuang's intention in displaying this painting?

For everyone to admire?

Liang Shi stood there looking at it for a while, feeling rather uncomfortable inside. Soon Liang Wanwan came over and exclaimed in admiration at the painting.

Liang Wanwan sighed: "I have to admit, Qin Lishuang is really amazing at painting people. The colors in this painting are more exquisite than her other works, the lines of the human body are just right, and the model's emotions come through the painting. It's extremely beautiful. However..."

Liang Wanwan paused and looked at Liang Shi beside her: "Jie, why does this look a bit like you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi played dumb: "Does it? I don't really see it."

Liang Wanwan nodded: "It does, especially the eyes."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Then I don't know." Liang Shi awkwardly touched the tip of her nose. "Let's go look elsewhere."

Even after Liang Wanwan had walked elsewhere, she was still thinking about that painting. When she turned around, she found many people gathered around that painting, all exclaiming in admiration.

"If she sold it, it would probably fetch a high price." Liang Wanwan muttered: "But Qin Lishuang doesn't lack money. Her family is very wealthy too."

Liang Shi gave a low cough, feeling as if she was being exposed under the sun, her whole body heating up.

Liang Shi made an excuse that she wanted to go to the restroom and fled from there, leaving Liang Wanwan alone to view the exhibition.

Artists do paint nudes, and there are professional nude models.

Both male and female.

The painting wasn't particularly explicit—somewhat like an artistic poster—but Liang Shi still felt uncomfortable looking at it.

For Qin Lishuang and the public, it was beauty, but that beauty was built upon the original owner's humiliation.

Knowing the inside story, Liang Shi couldn't look at that painting as objectively as Liang Wanwan.

There was no one in the art museum's restroom. Liang Shi calmed down for a while before going out.

She pushed open the stall door. Outside, a person wearing a bright yellow dress was washing her hands. Her back was plump, she had a wavy perm, and her movements were elegant.

After washing her hands, she pulled a paper towel from the side and dried her hands unhurriedly.

Liang Shi had indeed seen many elegant ladies today—those who could come here were no ordinary people.

And this lady was among the best, with every movement making one feel comfortable.

Liang Shi couldn't help but take a few more glances, washing her hands while stealing glances from the corner of her eye—though she looked discreetly without making the other person uncomfortable.

However, the lady soon left.

After washing her hands, Liang Shi pulled a paper towel to dry them. When she turned around, she noticed a gray bag on the sink—a designer brand worth over six figures, which could probably still sell for fifty or sixty thousand on a second-hand website.

It must have been left by that lady just now.

Liang Shi immediately grabbed the bag and hurried out. Because the other person's dress color was very conspicuous and easy to spot, Liang Shi called out from behind: "Ma'am."

The other person stopped and turned around.

Liang Shi quickly ran over. "Ma'am, your bag."

The other person was startled, then smiled helplessly after a moment: "I completely forgot about it. Thank you, young lady."

Liang Shi shook her head: "It's nothing."

This lady's voice was also very gentle, like a stream flowing softly—pleasant to hear and mood-lifting.

Liang Shi said: "You should check if anything's missing, though I didn't touch anything."

"There's nothing valuable inside." The other person smiled gently: "Thank you for the trouble."

Liang Shi smiled.

The other person studied Liang Shi for a moment. "Young lady, are you married?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"Ah..." Liang Shi gave a low cough: "Yes, I am."

The other person was obviously a bit disappointed: "Alright then."

Just as she finished speaking, someone jogged over. "Auntie."

Liang Shi looked up and happened to meet the other person's eyes. She was startled: "Yan Lin?"

Yan Lin was also stunned, but it took some effort to dig through her memory before she recalled: "Liang Shi?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Hello."

The woman caught in the middle was confused. "You two know each other?"

Liang Shi spoke first: "Not really. I just filmed a drama with Yan Xi before."

Yan Lin agreed: "Yes."

The woman thought for a moment, then smiled. "Alright, that's fate too. I didn't bring my business card today, so I won't give you one. However, my surname is Zhu. I should be a generation older than you—you can call me Auntie Zhu."

The woman extended her hand toward her.

Yan Lin, standing to the side, was dumbfounded.

This...?